

ASSABIAN RITES

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Incantations

Pre-Shaped Spells for today's busy working Sorcerer

This is an attempt at a more table-ready approach to sorcery – one in which the capabilities and costs of a sorcery spell are known in advance rather than engineered on the spot using the sorcery rules in the CRB. It is very much a beta at this stage and is not yet part of the Thennla world - but certainly one day could be. While this is aimed at making sorcery more player-friendly, it also has benefits to the GM – and to the scenario writer – where a spell listing with skills for an NPC doesn't give enough hard information on what an NPC can do, it leaves decisions and calculations to be made on the spot, at the table, during play. Sometimes limitation is liberation...

Design Principles

- This approach uses the Core Rule Book to provide basic principles and architecture of sorcery, but treats the spells in the CRB as starting points – each potentially a parent to multiple offspring in the form of pre-shaped spells I'm calling Incantations.
- Incantations come with pre-set Intensity, Range and Duration. An important change is that Intensity also requires Shaping points, and that means there is a practical limit to how powerful these spells can be.
- A sorcerer's Shaping points must be equal to or greater than total Shaping points that went into the design of the Incantation (including Intensity). Shaping is brought to the fore as the essential and defining sorcery skill. Invocation measures casting chance and in effect the chance of overcoming resistance, but does not affect the power of the Incantation.
- To balance the cost of Intensity, base Magnitude is set at the Magic Point cost of the Incantation, and can be overclocked by pumping additional Magic Points (but not additional Shaping Points) into the casting.
- If a sorcerer has more Shaping points available than those required for an Incantation, these can be used to:
 - a. Apply further manipulations that affect the spellcaster's Invocation roll (Focus) or the chance of overcoming a target's resistance (Precision)
 - b. Apply the Targets manipulation
 - c. Apply the Multispell manipulation
- Incantations can have functional variations or customisations to the parent sorcery spell. For example, there can be dozens of spells based on WRACK all with their own idiosyncrasies and limitations – not just one wrack spell with different visual/narrative effects. This provides many ways in which to add flavour to the magic of a campaign.
- Spells can be grouped into ranks in line with TMITIM for the purpose of who can learn what as they progress through the ranks of a sorcery order.

- Shaping elements for Incantations are standardised (instead of being based on caster POW). So if a spell can have the Ranged attribute, base range is 10m.
- Base duration is set in multiples of 10 Minutes rather than caster's POW. The RAW table for increase in Duration is, in my opinion, not terribly useful – by simply providing an extra multiple in minutes for each Shaping Point spent, little worthwhile gain is made. The base Duration already lasts well beyond the time required for most encounters but is not enough to bridge the time gap until the next; and the high duration multiples don't open up tactical or narrative options worth the cost.

Sorcery Traditions, Grimoires and Spell Books

Many different sorcery traditions exist, each with its own approach to what magic is used for and how, and so each has its own limited corpus of spells. A sorcery tradition is encapsulated by the idea of a Grimoire. A Grimoire is, at least by origin, a physical object in which a specific magical tradition is recorded and curated, although it does not necessarily have to be a book. The contents of a Grimoire usually include at least 5 spells from the Mythras CRB, recorded and described as a set of highly complex instructions and protocols.

However most practitioners only have access to lesser, secondary works, typically spell-books in which these spells have been translated into pre-shaped lesser spells, or Incantations. There may be several spell-books deriving from each Grimoire, each perhaps with only one incantation or with a handful of them – some grimoires have in fact spawned dozens of incantations as different permutations of the spells contained therein.

Invocation

Invocation represents the sorcerer's command of a specific body of magical lore, and so their skill in casting spells written or created out of that tradition. There are many different traditions and schools to choose from, each with their own Invocation skill. Some of these traditions are connected or related, so there are cases where an Invocation skill from one Grimoire can be used for spells derived from another, at one or more grades of difficulty harder, a bit like substituting related languages.

Shaping

This skill is the true measure of a sorcerer's competence. The sorcerer has Shaping Points equal to 1/10 of this skill (round up), and can only cast Incantations of a level equal to or less than their Shaping Points

Incantations: Features and Limitations

The act of creating an Incantation has many creative possibilities, and a few effects: key characteristics, including Intensity, range and duration usually become fixed. Some of the spell's characteristics are customised towards specific purpose and use, this often involves a trade-off of power compared to the Core spell on which the spell is based. Every facet of the incantation, including Intensity, demands the use of Shaping Points, which can limit the power it is possible to achieve. Some typical features of incantations:

- An incantation is often limited to a specific species or type of creature as a target. Such spells must have a minimum Intensity to affect a target that is an average specimen of the target species

- Range and Duration are standardised rather than based on caster POW; base Range (after Touch) is 10m and base Duration for a Temporal spell (after Instant) is 10 minutes
- Targets manipulation is often situation-specific and so this remains a form of shaping that can be applied at point of casting.
- however two versions of the Target manipulation – Multi-spell and Charges can form part of the pre-shaped Incantation.
- An incantation is often customised, trading off some of the power of the spell it is based on to achieve a new effect. For example an incantation based on Wrack that delivers less damage per intensity but also gains an effect such as bypassing natural armour, stunning the location affected or being harder to heal

Targets and Multispelling

Targets can be used to produce multiple simultaneous instances of the same spell. A typical use might be to produce a spray of magic missiles rather than just one, with one additional missile per Shaping Point applied. Multispell effects are always directed at the same target but can affect different locations on that target

Charges

This manipulation allows for re-use of a spell that is otherwise Instant. So for example a Necrotic Touch spell that is otherwise one-use could be repeated a number of times equal to the Shaping Points spent on the Charges manipulation within the Duration of the spell and subject to the sorcerer maintaining or restoring Concentration. Depending on the Incantation a Charge may be directed at a different target subject to overcoming any Resistance Rolls

Incantation Levels

An incantation's level is the Intensity plus the total number of Shaping Points used in its design.

Incantation Magic Point Cost is determined as normal, being 1MP for each element involved (e.g. Intensity, Range and Duration results in a 3MP cost spell).

Incantation Magnitude is equal to the MP cost of the spell. All spells can have their Magnitude increased if the sorcerer expends additional Magic Points on a one-for-one basis.

Incantation Casting Time equals the Magnitude in Turns unless otherwise stated in the spell's description

Intensity Required to affect target Where a spell's Intensity is measured against a characteristic or attribute of the target, the Intensity of the Incantation need only be set at a level sufficient to affect an average specimen, so long as the target is in the normal range for a creature of its species (ie for a human, in the 3-18 or 8-18 range). So for example an Incantation derived from a spell affecting a target with a SIZ no more than 3 times its Intensity must be set at Intensity 5 to affect any human target (whether SIZ 9 or SIZ 18!). Intensity 4 would be sufficient for a spell measured against human STR, CON, POW, DEX or CHA.

Where the target is an area of effect, a volume of material or similar that is found by a multiple of the spell's Intensity, then Core rules apply as normal; hence an Intensity 5 Animate Wood can affect a maximum of 15 SIZ of Wood.

Sorcery Rank and TMITIM

Spells and Incantations are ranked from Novice to Magus according to who has the proficiency to learn and use them, based on the sorcerer's Shaping skill. The master spells contained in a grimoire usually require a sorcerer to be of Master level or greater. This provides some guidance for progression within a Sorcery Order. For example, let's assume a typical Sorcery Order had magical resources available amounting to: 5 sorcery spells; 9 Incantations derived from those Sorcery spells; and at least 7-10 Folk Magic Spells (Cantrips). We can imagine the Order allows progressively wider access to this magical lore as a sorcerer progresses through the ranks

Incantation Level	Shaping Skill	Sorcery Rank	Cantrips (Folk Magic) Available	Incantations Available	CORE Spells Available
1-3	01-30%	Novice	3	2	0
4-5	31-50%	Apprentice	7	5	0
6-7	51-70%	Adept	Unlimited	7	1
8-9	71-90%	Master	Unlimited	Unlimited	3
10-11	91-110%	Magus	Unlimited	Unlimited	Unlimited
12+	111%+	Ascendant	Unlimited	Unlimited	Unlimited

Further Shaping an Incantation

If a Sorcerer's Shaping skill is sufficient to offer more Shaping Points than an Incantation requires, there are some ways in which these can be used to further manipulate the casting:

- 1) Intensity, Duration and Range may not be further manipulated unless this is explicitly allowed for in the Incantation description
- 2) Targets can be increased
- 3) Incantations cannot be Combined
- 4) Ablation, Focus and Precision can all be applied if the Sorcerer knows them

Spell Traits

Spell Trait	
Charged	The caster can charge an otherwise instant spell with additional uses by spending Shaping Points, allowing, for example, repeated attacks in subsequent turns
Charm	A spell where the Duration is measured in natural rhythms of time – hours of daylight and darkness, lunar cycles, seasons, solar cycle, created using Combine (Enchant) plus Duration
Combination	The Incantation has been created by a combination of two spells
Concentration	A spell that is only active or can only be triggered so long as the caster maintains concentration on it.
Conditional	A spell that only takes effect when certain conditions stated by the caster at time of casting are fulfilled
Cost	The spell's cost in Magic Points if not boosted to increase Magnitude
Enchantment	A spell where the Duration is Permanent except for conditions set by the sorcerer, created using Combine (Enchant).
Incantation	A pre-shaped spell derived from one or more Sorcery Spells found in a Grimoire
Instant	The spell takes effect on the Turn on which the casting is completed and has no further effect other than the changes it has made or damage caused to the target.

Ranged	A spell that can be cast at a target within a specified Range. Base range is 10 meters. If the spell description allows it to be extended the Range doubles with each point of Shaping applied
Sorcery Spell	As capitalised, referring to the sorcery spells listed in the Mythras CRB. version of a magical procedure from which spells are derived, the knowledge to cast such spells is generally allowed only to sorcerers of Magus rank and above.
Targeted	A spell that can be directed at more than one target with the same casting
Temporal	A spell that carries a Duration measured in minutes. Base duration is 10 Minutes, if the spell descriptions allows it to be extended the Duration doubles with each point of Shaping applied
Touch	A spell that can only be applied to the sorcerer himself or to a target she is in physical contact with
Trigger	A spell that is cast but does not take effect until certain conditions are met

Sample Incantations

The samples here spring from various forms of Wrack (CRB p. xxx). An amended damage table has been applied as some of these Incantations are one-shot attacks, and so have been given an increase to the damage roll.

Magical Damage Table		
Intensity	Base Damage: Instant Spells	Base Damage/Turn
1-2	1d4	1d2
3-4	1d6	1d4
5-6	1d8	1d6
7-8	1d10	1d8
9-10	1d12	1d10
11+	1d12+1d2	1d12

Jolt (Novice)

Level 1 Wrack spell, Touch, Instant, Cost 1MP

The sorcerer's hand is charged to deliver a sudden shock to a target causing 1d4 damage to the location touched, ignoring worn armour. If the target fails to resist the spell (Endurance) the location struck is also Stunned for 1d3 turns. Best used as a sneak attack, however if the target is actively attempting to avoid contact the sorcerer must be within Touch reach and make a successful Unarmed attack of some kind to deliver the spell. If striking an opponent, the 1d4 is treated as additional damage (ie in addition to natural weapon damage and damage modifier).

Magic Missiles (Apprentice)

Level 5 Wrack Spell, Ranged 2 (20m), Instant, Cost 2 MP

Shards of magical energy dart from the sorcerer's hand, striking a single target that fails to Evade for 1d6 Damage to a random location, ignoring worn armour. If the caster has available Shaping Points they can be used to add additional missiles.

Necrotic Touch (Adept)

Level 6 Wrack spell, Intensity 5, Touch, Temporal 1 (10 minutes), Cost 2 MP

The sorcerer lays hands upon an unsuspecting or helpless victim delivering a deadly touch, mortifying the victims flesh, inflicting 1d6 Damage. The tissue affected is dead and the damage cannot recover by normal healing but requires magic to regenerate. Worn armour protects against this damage.

Apparently there is an order of necromancers in Morkesh who receive this as a 'blessing'. Touched by their Magus, they are given a ghastly, skull-like visage, a 'no going back' commitment in return for access to some of the higher secrets of their order. The weak, unlucky or disfavoured do not survive the experience.

Lord of Lightning (Adept)

Level 7 Wrack Spell, Ranged (10m), Concentration, Temporal (10 mins) Cost 2MP

Arcs of crackling magical-electrical energy leaps from the caster's fingertips that deliver 1d6 damage to a target if the target fails to Evade, ignoring any worn armour

Glyph of Warding (Adept)

Level 7 Wrack Spell, Permanent Until Triggered, Touch, Conditional

Cost 2MP plus +1 per additional charge

A Glyph of Warding is in effect a magical trap that will release its power upon someone who transgresses the Conditions that have been set. So for example, a box containing a valuable arcane scroll may bear a Glyph of Warding that will be set off by anyone touching it who is not supposed to as described by a Condition spoken by the caster. The Glyph inflicts 1d8 damage.

This spell remains in place until its triggering conditions are met, and once it has been triggered it becomes inert; however if the Sorcerer has Shaping points available, they can load the Glyph with additional charges in which case the spell only expires when all charges have been triggered, or provide additional conditions to describe in more detail who it should and should not affect.

Dismemberment (Master)

Level 8 Wrack spell, Concentration, Ranged 1 (10m), Temporal 1 (10 Minutes), Multispell 3, Cost: 4 MP

This spell literally tears its victim limb from limb. Dismemberment affects four locations (arms, legs) of the target simultaneously, delivering 1d4 damage per location in each of the caster's turns so long as concentration is maintained. Natural and magical armour protect only until their protection value is exceeded by accumulated damage. The sorcerer can continue to inflict damage on his turn until each location reaches negative hit points equal to or greater than its starting Hit Points, at which point it is severed from the rest of the body.

A caster with Shaping Points available can increase (or decrease) the number of locations simultaneously affected by one per point of Shaping applied. In the case of increasing the number of locations affected, on a humanoid target this enables the caster to affect vital locations (head, chest, abdomen). However in the case of a creature with more than four limbs the additional limbs will always be affected before vital locations.

The Dismemberment spell is apparently used as a form of (public) execution in the Sultanate of Jelhai.